

# You're unemployed now. What actually works.

Straight talk for experienced professionals — what the research says, what people wish they'd known on day one, and what to do first.

IF YOU TAKE NOTHING ELSE AWAY FROM THIS GUIDE

The five things that matter most

- Calculate your exact runway in months before you do anything else
- 70% of jobs are filled through networks — not posted publicly. Applications are your worst-ROI activity.
- Update LinkedIn and secure references in week one, before you approach the market
- Around week five, everyone hits a wall. It's not a sign the search is failing. Push through it.
- Accepting the wrong offer because the search was exhausting costs more than four more weeks of searching

Most career transition advice is optimistic to the point of uselessness. This guide tries to be accurate instead.

The job search for experienced professionals is longer, harder, and more psychologically demanding than most expect. The average search at the manager level and above takes four to six months. Many take longer. Knowing that on day one changes every decision you make.

70%

of jobs filled through networks — never posted publicly  
*LinkedIn Economic Graph, 2023*

2-3%

response rate on cold job applications  
*Jobscan / CareerBuilder*

5×

more likely to get an interview via referral vs. cold application  
*Federal Reserve Bank of NY, 2021*

The implication: most candidates spend their time on the activity with the lowest return — applications — and avoid the one with the highest return — conversations with people who know their work.

*"The myth of the job search is that effort produces results. The truth is that the right kind of effort produces results. Most candidates work hard at the wrong things."*

Lou Adler, Hire With Your Head — 25 years of recruiting research

THE FIRST WEEK — SEQUENCE MATTERS

## Foundation before activation

The most expensive mistake in a search is starting too fast. Do these four things before you approach the market.

## 1. Get a precise financial number — today

Liquid savings ÷ monthly expenses = your runway in months. Not a rough sense — an actual number. Candidates who know they have six months make different decisions than those who feel like they're running out of time. Most professional searches close in 90–180 days. Most people have more runway than they think once they calculate it precisely.

- File for unemployment benefits this week — eligibility windows are strict
- Make the COBRA vs. ACA decision within 30 days (you have 60, but act early)
- Do not touch your 401k — the tax and penalty cost is almost never worth it
- Have one clear money conversation with your partner with real numbers, not feelings
- Identify bridge income options: consulting, fractional work, expert networks (GLG, Bolster)

### NEXTCHAPTER TOOL

The Benefits & Financial Bridge walks you through COBRA vs. ACA, severance decisions, and your real runway in your first session. Free at [launchournextchapter.com](https://launchournextchapter.com)

## 2. Secure your references before anyone asks for them

The time to reach out to references is now — before any company asks. References briefed in advance, reminded of the specific accomplishments you want highlighted, give specific and compelling recommendations. References called without warning give vague ones. The difference shows, and you control it entirely.

- Identify five: a manager, peer, direct report, client if possible, and a stretch reference
- Message each personally — not a group email, not a LinkedIn connection request
- Tell them your target and two or three specific things you'd like them to mention

## 3. Fix LinkedIn before you send anything

Every recruiter, hiring manager, and contact checks LinkedIn within minutes of any interaction with you. A stale headline from your old employer, a blank "About" section, and no indication of what you're targeting undermines everything you send. This takes two hours. It's the two highest-return hours of week one.

- Headline: not "Seeking opportunities" — name your function, level, and one differentiator
- Open to Work: set to "Recruiters only" — not the public green ring, which signals desperation to some hiring managers
- About section: one clear paragraph — what you've done, what you bring, what you're targeting
- Export your LinkedIn connections as CSV now — you'll need it for the Warm Path Finder

### NEXTCHAPTER TOOL

Victoria's Narrative Builder creates your LinkedIn headline, About section, and résumé summary from a single 20-minute guided conversation — consistent across every surface.

## 4. Write your story — one version, said confidently

You will be asked to explain your situation dozens of times. Three sentences: what happened briefly, what you took from it, where you're focused. Whether you were laid off, left voluntarily, or departed under difficult circumstances, there is a version that is honest and professionally acceptable. Write it. Say it out loud five times. If it still sounds defensive after five repetitions, rewrite it.

### NEXTCHAPTER TOOL

Victoria's Narrative Builder handles gap explanations, career pivots, and difficult departures — generating six surface versions from one core story, including your verbal "tell me about yourself."

#### THE MISTAKE THAT COSTS MONTH FOUR

Sending bulk applications in week one — before your narrative is clear, materials updated, or any conversations started — produces almost no results. A cold application from a candidate whose LinkedIn still shows their old company, with a narrative that hasn't been thought through, lands in an ATS and disappears. The ROI on one well-prepared personal conversation in week one is greater than 30 unfocused applications.

#### THE ANXIETY MAP

### Every fear, named and answered

Unnamed fear drives bad decisions: urgency, over-explaining, accepting the wrong offer, or paralysis. Name them precisely and they lose power over the process.

#### The gap will disqualify me

A 2022 LinkedIn study found 79% of hiring managers willing to interview candidates with résumé gaps. Gaps under 12 months, explained confidently and without apology, rarely eliminate candidates at the senior level. What disqualifies candidates is the visible anxiety — over-explaining, pre-emptive justification, body language that signals shame. The gap is not the problem. How you carry it is.

- ✓ Prepare your gap explanation: one sentence. Say it once. Then move forward.
- ✓ Candidates who dwell on it teach interviewers to dwell on it.

#### NEXTCHAPTER TOOL

Interview Practice generates gap-specific questions for your exact situation and coaches your answers until they land with confidence — before you're in the room.

### No one is responding to my applications

ATS systems filter approximately 75% of applications before a human reads them (Jobscan, 2023). Among those that reach a recruiter, most are reviewed in under 10 seconds. A 2-3% response rate on cold applications is not a reflection of your value. It is the normal behavior of the channel.

- After 10-15 applications with no response: stop submitting, start reaching out
- The correct response to silence is not more applications — it is a different channel

#### NEXTCHAPTER TOOL

Route to Role generates a specific pursuit plan for every role you're interested in — who in your network has a path in, whether to apply cold or network first, the exact first action.

### I'm not good at networking

Research on weak ties (Granovetter, 1973; replicated consistently since) shows job leads most often come from acquaintances, not close contacts. What most people call "networking" — attending events, messaging strangers — is genuinely uncomfortable because it should be. Reconnecting with people who already know your work and asking for a conversation is not networking. It is a warm interaction with someone who already has reason to help you.

- ✓ List 25 people who have seen your work firsthand
- ✓ Message three of them this week — personal message, not a connection request
- ✓ Ask for a 15-minute conversation, not a job. The conversation leads to the job.

#### NEXTCHAPTER TOOL

Outreach Scripts generates 9 message variants calibrated to your relationship warmth and networking anxiety level — in your voice. The Support Network 5x5 builder maps your full contact universe.

I don't know how to explain why I left

Three sentences: what happened briefly, what you learned or what changed, where you're focused now. Whether it's a layoff, performance exit, culture conflict, or health or family interruption — there is a version that is both honest and professionally acceptable. The version that doesn't work is a long detailed account that leaves the interviewer wondering about the other side of the story.

- ✓ Write it. Show it to someone who doesn't know the story.
- ✓ Ask: what questions does this raise? Answer those in advance.

I'm running out of money

Financial anxiety compresses decision-making in dangerous ways — it makes the first offer feel like the right offer. The counter is precision, not optimism. "I have five months of runway" is plannable. "I'm running out of money" is paralyzing. They may describe the same situation.

- Calculate runway once, precisely. Recalculate monthly — not daily.
- Bridge income options that don't require long-term commitment: expert networks (GLG, AlphaSights pay \$200-\$500/hour for your expertise), fractional consulting, part-time advisory roles

The week-five wall

Around week five, virtually every professional search hits a period of low motivation and disproportionate discouragement. The initial energy is gone. Results haven't arrived yet. This is not a signal the search is failing — it is the normal shape of a search. Research on job search psychology (Wanberg et al., 2012) identifies this as the most predictive moment: candidates who push through week five substantially improve their outcome. Those who don't, don't.

- ✓ Know week five is coming before it arrives
- ✓ Make no major strategy changes without data to support them in the first six weeks
- ✓ You will feel different by week seven. Continue.

THE MISTAKES

What people wish they'd done differently

- ✗ **Waiting too long to reach out to their network.** Most candidates wait until desperate. Reaching out early, when you're calm and not under pressure, produces better conversations and better information.
- ✗ **Not updating LinkedIn until after sending applications.** Every recruiter looks at your LinkedIn profile first. A stale headline undermines everything you sent.
- ✗ **Treating every week the same regardless of results.** After six weeks of consistent effort with no conversations, the problem is not effort — it's the target, message, or positioning. Change one variable. Test. Repeat.
- ✗ **Not briefing references before the call.** References called without preparation give generic answers. Briefed references give specific ones. You control this entirely and most candidates don't use the leverage.
- ✗ **Telling people they were "exploring options."** Vague language makes it impossible for contacts to route opportunities to you. "VP Finance roles in healthcare or fintech, New York or remote" is specific enough to be useful. "Exploring options" is not.
- ✗ **Accepting the first offer because the search was exhausting.** A bad hire — from the candidate's perspective as well as the company's — typically ends within 18 months. That means another search. The cost of four more weeks is almost always lower than the cost of the wrong role.
- ✗ **Not asking what happened to the last person in the role.** The answer tells you more about the role than any job description. Ask before you accept.

THE PLAN

# What a serious search looks like — in sequence

## Weeks 1-2: Foundation

Financial clarity. LinkedIn fixed. References secured. Target defined with specificity. Not "a leadership role in finance" — "CFO or VP Finance at a Series B-D company in healthcare or fintech." The more specific the target, the more useful every conversation becomes and the more clearly contacts can route opportunities to you.

## Weeks 3-7: Activation

Three to five real conversations per week with people in your network or target space. Not applications — conversations. Track every contact, every conversation, every next step. One person who introduces you is worth more than 40 cold applications.

### NEXTCHAPTER TOOL

The Warm Path Finder shows you who in your LinkedIn network has a connection to every company you're targeting — so you reach out warm, not cold.

## Weeks 6-10: Market reading

By week six you have real data. If outreach rate is strong but conversations aren't converting, the problem is positioning. If you're not getting responses, the problem is the message or the target. Change one variable at a time. A search that reads its data and adjusts closes faster than one that adds volume.

## Weeks 8-12: Conversion

When conversations produce interview processes, shift your time toward preparation. Know your compensation floor before the first HR call. Prepare ten career stories. Practice them out loud — not in your head. The candidates who lose at this stage almost always lose on preparation, not on substance.

### NEXTCHAPTER TOOLS

Interview Practice generates role-specific questions and coaches your answers. Cover Letter Generator writes a tailored cover letter from your Proof Assets for any specific role. Resume Tailor highlights which of your accomplishments are most relevant to each job description.

## GETTING MORE HELP

# When professional support is worth it

## Executive recruiters

Retained recruiters (Spencer Stuart, Korn Ferry, Heidrick & Struggles, Russell Reynolds) are paid by the company — their job is to fill a specific role, not manage your search. Contingency recruiters are paid only if you're placed. Both are worth engaging when you fit their current mandates exactly. A recruiter who doesn't cover your function and level is not useful regardless of their reputation.

- Identify 3-5 boutique firms that specifically cover your function and seniority level
- One conversation with a recruiter who covers your space outperforms ten with those who don't

## Career coaches

The right career coach provides the outside perspective you cannot give yourself — catching the narrative that sounds convincing to you but doesn't land externally, seeing the positioning problem you can't see. Ask specifically: who have they worked with at your level, and what were the outcomes. If you've been searching eight weeks without traction, the right coach is worth the investment.

### NEXTCHAPTER TOOL

NextChapter certified coaches see your full profile, grade trajectory, and Victoria's observations before your first session — so you start from context, not from scratch. Coaching waitlist at [launchournextchapter.com](https://launchournextchapter.com)

The professionals who navigate this period well are not the ones who had an easier search. They are the ones who treated it as a professional project — with the same clarity, discipline, and evidence-based approach they would bring to any consequential work.

Stay specific. Keep reaching out. Turn down the wrong offer even when it's frightening to do so.

That is the entire playbook.